THE

ARCANE AETHER

A rules-light fantasy game about rewriting reality

VERSION 4.6 · INITIAL FULL-BOOK DRAFT

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The Arcane Aether

The Arcane Aether is a rules-light fantasy game about ordinary people who discover that reality can be rewritten.
I am trying to explore two ideas with these rules:

- Can magic stay open-ended and weird while still being fun at the table?
- Can a simple system let characters progress during play, as a direct result of the choices made in a session?

It is inspired by Powered by the Apocalypse, Shadowdark, Blades in the Dark, Cairn, and other games where characters take shape through play.
I am not very concerned with encounter balance, and the game does not offer many guardrails. I want something quick to learn and quick to get into play, with room for silly, out-of-the-box ideas. I also like the thought that you can borrow magic from any other game and see what it does here.
As a GM, I like to play to find out and leave room for freeform play. I want simple monster creation and fast, fluid fights when the players decide to fight.

Origin of magic relics

Why are there so many magic items? Why do the people capable of making them keep leaving them in tombs, shops, and holes in the ground?
In this game, Arcanists make magic items because they need somewhere to put their Exposure before it changes them. They pour it into objects, use those objects for a while, and eventually have to leave some of them behind.
Every relic came from someone with a problem. That was the idea I wanted to explore, and the rest of the game grew around it.

What makes it different

There is no spell list. A player says what they want their character's magic to do. The GM assigns one Magic Magnitude for the whole effect, then the player decides if it is worth the Exposure.
You do not need to predict every possible spell. You just need to understand what the player is asking for and make the Exposure cost clear.

Advance by trying in play

I want character progression to happen while everyone is playing, not as a separate downtime step or paperwork after the game. Characters gain Luck when things go badly and when they complete their goals.
Players can spend that Luck to improve their character's stats, help one another, or play out a flashback scene that changes the present scene. Players learn to be better at casting by attempting to cast, but at the cost of slowly collecting mutations that fill up their limited inventory. It should be clear that all obstacles in this game are solvable through magic and teamwork.

Monsters should be easy to run

A monster needs four numbers and answers to two questions: what does it want, and what is its weakness?
Monster tiers are numbered 1 to 6. When I do not want to decide how dangerous something should be, I let the dice decide.
I do not think every encounter needs to be balanced. Tell the players what their characters can see, let them decide what risks to take, and follow the consequences. The monster's Desire also leaves room for a bargain when another attack roll would be less interesting.

Strange ideas are allowed to work

Not everything needs a roll. Let the silly ideas move the story. Maybe a character knows how to speak Orc because they once spent a summer in an Orc camp pretending to be a baby Orc's doll, that sounds good to me.

Core Rules

Core Mechanics

The dice

Say what your character intends to do. **Roll 2d6 plus the fitting stat.** Casting uses one relevant Spell Tag instead. Roll when the outcome is uncertain and failure would change the situation. Otherwise, let it happen or tell the player what it costs in time or resources.

Total	Result
6 or less	Failure. It goes wrong. Resolve the failure, then gain 1 Luck.
7 to 9	Partial success. Your character does it, but there is a complication.
10 or greater	Full success. Your character achieves what they intended.
Double 1s	Tragic failure.
Double 6s	Critical success.

Check doubles on the two dice that determine the result. Double 1s or double 6s replace the normal result.
When no more specific doubles rule applies, the GM adds a severe or lasting consequence to a Tragic failure. On a Critical success, your character achieves what they intended and gains an extra benefit chosen by the GM.
A complication should move events forward. Your character might lose something, end up in danger, attract attention, or get hurt. A partial success still accomplishes what you rolled for.

Luck

Each character can hold up to **10 Luck**.
At the table, use spare 6 sided dice or tokens to track Luck. Each die or token represents 1 Luck, regardless of the number showing on the die. Collect them as you gain Luck and return them as you spend it. At the end of the session, record the remaining total in the Luck box on your character sheet. Use that total to set out your dice or tokens next session.
Gain **1 Luck** after you accept and resolve a failed roll. Gain **2 Luck** when your character achieves a Key Goal and you cross it off their list. Or roll double 1s.
You may give your Luck to another player whenever you like.

Spending Luck

Cost	Buy
1	Add one die to your roll and keep the highest two.
1	Assist another character. With their roll by rolling 1 dice with them.
2	Play a flashback that can affect the present.
5	Advance character stat.

Add a die

Spend 1 Luck before resolving a roll. Roll **3d6 and keep the highest two**. Only the kept dice count for double 1s or double 6s.

Assist another character

Spend 1 Luck and explain how your character helps. The active player adds 1d6 to their roll and keeps the highest two dice.
If the roll fails, only the active player gains 1 Luck. Everyone who assisted shares the consequences of a failure or partial success.
You can spend a luck to assist while the other player is spending a luck to add a dice.

Flashbacks

Spend 2 Luck to play a short scene from your character's past that affects the present. Maybe they bribed the kitchen servant to leave the back door unlocked.
Play the scene and roll if its outcome is uncertain. Then return to the present with the result. Costs and consequences apply normally. In a turn, the flashback counts as your character's action.

Advancement

Spend 5 Luck to choose one:

- Increase a stat by 1, to a maximum of +3.
- Increase a Spell Tag by 1, to a maximum of +3.
- Increase maximum Health by 1.
- Gain an Archetype Perk.

Inventory and conditions

Your inventory is a mix of the things you have on you and your health bar.
Your character has **12 inventory slots**. Gear fills from the top down. Conditions fill from the bottom up, taking the lowest available slot.
An item usually takes one slot. Small things of the same kind bundle together, such as a handful of arrows, spikes, or three rations. Worn armor does not take a slot.
Mutations, Scars, and Fatigue are conditions. If one takes a slot holding an item, that item is dropped.
When conditions claim all twelve slots, the character is lost. The final condition determines what happens in Death and dying.

Movement

A move shifts your character one zone toward or away from something. Skip their action to take a second move.

Zone	Meaning
Close	Melee. Close enough to touch.
Near	Across the room. One move to Close.
Far	Two moves from Close. Bowshot.

Walls, locked doors, crowds, and deep holes still matter.

Combat

Characters act first, then enemies. The players roll 1d6. The highest roll goes first, then play moves clockwise around the table. If the characters are surprised, the attackers act first.

Your character's turn

Your character can take **one move and one action** in either order. They can attack, cast, catch their breath, use something, assist someone, or try something else.

Roll **2d6 plus Strength** for hand-to-hand combat or **2d6 plus Dexterity** for a ranged attack. Your character must be able to reach the target with what they are using.

Result	Effect
Failure	The attack fails and the situation gets worse.
Partial success	Deal the weapon's damage and suffer a complication.
Full success	Deal double the weapon's damage.
Double 6s	Deal triple damage and ignore Armor.
Double 1s	The attack fails. The character takes 1 damage or their weapon breaks, whichever fits.
Triple 6s	You daftly kill your target.
Triple 1s	Take a scare and drop your weapon. You blundered so bad you fell and hurt yourself.

On a failure or partial success, an enemy may hurt your character, push them back, damage their gear, or create another fitting complication. The enemy still takes its regular turn.

Damage and Armor

Damage uses the same magnitude names as magic:

Damage magnitude	Damage
Tiny	0
Small	1
Medium	2
Large	3
Huge	4
Mythic	8

These names describe damage, not the size of the weapon or the monster's tier. Damage modifiers, doubling, tripling, and Armor still apply normally. A Mythic monster still follows its own Weakness rules in Monsters.

Weapons deal damage based on their size and weight:

- Small or concealable: **Small damage (1)**.
- Normal: **Medium damage (2)**.
- Heavy or two-handed: **Large damage (3)**.

Apply damage added by a Perk before doubling or tripling the attack.

Armor reduces incoming damage. Worn armor and shields stack to a maximum of **3 Armor**, although Mythic creatures may have more.

When your character takes damage, subtract their Armor. If the damage exceeds the Armor, apply the remaining damage and the Armor breaks. If the damage does not exceed the Armor, apply no damage and leave the Armor intact.

A critical success ignores Armor without breaking it.

Broken Armor must be repaired by someone with the necessary skills. Pay them or owe them a favor.

When enemies attack

Use the enemy's Threat from Monsters. The GM rolls **2d6 plus Threat**.

Total	Result
6 or less	The attack misses.
7 to 9	Deal the enemy's listed damage.
10 or greater	Deal the enemy's listed damage and cause a complication.
Double 6s	Deal triple damage and ignore Armor.
Double 1s	The attack fails and the enemy suffers a mishap.

A crowd attacking one target rolls once, using its highest Threat and best single damage. Its numbers can still block exits, surround a character, or create other complications.

Casting Magic

Magical casting

Your character can command the patterns of Aether and reshape reality through thought and imagination.

1. Describe the effect and desired magnitude. This can be total effect in size or duration or both.
2. Once the cost has been agreed on, then roll 2d6 plus one relevant Spell Tag.
3. If there was a success mark the exposure.

Casting follows the normal roll results, with these additional effects:

- **Double 1s:** The cast fails spectacularly. Your character gains no Exposure. Roll d66 on the Wild Magic table.
- **Double 6s:** The cast executes spectacularly. Mark the Exposure and then gain, or improve a Spell Tag as described below.

A beneficial flourish to the cast can be added to the scene when it makes sense in the story.

Spell Tags
Spell Tags represent what your character has learned through casting. Fire, invisibility, healing, ice, mind reading, floating, talking to animals, light, pain, and poison are all possible Tags.
Choose one relevant Spell Tag for each cast and add its rating to the roll. Tags do not stack, run out, reduce Exposure, or limit what your character may attempt.
Without a relevant Tag, roll 2d6 with no bonus.
Casting does not use a Stat. Only one relevant Spell Tag can add to the roll.

Learning Spell Tags
When your character attempts a cast without a relevant Spell Tag, write down a fitting Tag with an empty four-segment clock. An unfinished Tag adds no bonus to the roll.
After each successful cast that fits the Tag, fill one segment. Partial and full successes count. When the fourth segment is filled, erase the clock and record the Tag at +1.
When your character gains a Mutation through casting or you roll double 6s on a cast, choose one instead of filling a clock segment:

- Complete an unfinished Tag related to the cast at +1.
- Gain a new +1 Tag related to the cast.
- Increase the Tag used by 1, to a maximum of +3.

If both a Mutation and double 6s happen on the same cast, gain this benefit only once.
The Spell Tags table is a prompt sheet, not a spell list.

Magic Magnitude
The magnitude should be, player facing, simple and fast at the table. Its cost should inform the players choice in how big they want their cast to be.
Over all the segments are based on the spell's overall scale, power, reach, damage, and duration. But don't sweat the small stuff, pick a number and keep the story moving.

Magnitude	Exposure	Damage guideline	Example
Tiny	1	0	Create a harmless spark on something the character touches.
Small	2	1	Give one nearby creature a firm magical shove.
Medium	4	2	Fill a room with an illusion for a scene.
Large	6	3	Hide a building or group of buildings behind an illusion.
Huge	8	4	Cover a field or city in magical fog.
Mythic	10	8	Permanently transform a whole building into a living creature.

For scrying, mind reading, and other information magic, consider how far away the subject is, what the character learns, and how long they observe. Discovery, misleading visions, or the subject sensing the intrusion may still be consequences when they fit.
Casting effects end when their agreed duration expires. A portal closes, a transformed person returns to their previous form, invisibility ends, and a flying boat comes back down.

Magical healing
Medium magic handles simple injuries, normally restoring 2 Health. Large magic handles major wounds, normally restoring 3 Health, or removing one Scar. The GM considers the whole effect when assigning magnitude, including how many characters it heals and how long it lasts.
Damage and healing normally happen instantly and remain afterward. Each character can benefit from a healing zone once per cast.

Exposure and Mutation
Exposure is a little like radiation poisoning. It collects as your character uses the Arcane Aether, letting them reshape the world while it reshapes them.
Whenever the character reaches **10 Exposure**, they undergo a Mutation. Roll on the Mutation table.
The Mutation permanently occupies an inventory slot.
Subtract 10 Exposure and keep any excess.

Magic Items and Dispersing Exposure

Magic items
An Arcanist, or caster, can move Exposure out of their body and into an object, creating a magical relic.
A relic:

- Takes one inventory slot.
- Holds up to **10 Exposure**.
- Takes an undisturbed hour to create or refill.
- Has one magical function chosen when it is created.
- Can be created or refilled once per in-game day.

Creating a new relic consumes **2 of the character's current Exposure**. This Exposure is spent, not stored.
During the same hour, choose how much additional Exposure to transfer, up to the relic's capacity. Subtract it from the character's current Exposure and record it in the relic.
For example, creating a relic with 4 stored Exposure removes 6 Exposure from the character: 2 to make the object magical and 4 to store. A new relic may start empty. Refilling an existing relic costs only the Exposure transferred, with no creation cost.
Anyone who can operate the relic can activate it. Describe an effect within the relic's function. The GM assigns its Magic Magnitude using the normal casting guidelines. Subtract that magnitude's Exposure cost from the relic's

stored Exposure. No casting roll is made, and the character using it gains no Exposure.

The relic cannot produce an activation that costs more Exposure than it currently holds. At zero Exposure, it is inert until an Arcanist refills it. It remains a relic and does not need the creation cost paid again.

Get creative with your magic items. Like a soul jar thats holds more gear, a fork that shoots fire balls, gloves that put people to sleep.

Relics can be traded or sold like other valuable objects.

Dying and Recovery

Health, Scars, and recovery

Subtract damage from your character's current Health. Their Archetype sets the maximum. Health cannot fall below zero.

Reaching zero Health does not cause a Scar. When your character takes damage while already at zero Health, mark one Scar. A single hit causes only one Scar, regardless of how much damage it deals.

Each Scar occupies an inventory slot until removed. Restoring Health does not remove Scars.

Fatigue

Mark 1 Fatigue when your character goes without proper rest or food, or consumes poison. Each Fatigue occupies one inventory slot.

Healing

- **One quiet hour in a safe place:** Roll 2d6 and restore that much Health.
- **A full night's rest:** Remove all Fatigue and restore all Health.

To catch their breath, spend the character's action and roll **2d6 plus Willpower**.

Total	Result
6 or less	Restore no Health. The situation gets worse. After resolving the failure, gain 1 Luck.
7 to 9	Restore 1 Health.
10 or greater	Restore 2 Health.
Double 1s	Restore no Health and resolve a Tragic failure.
Double 6s	Restore 3 Health. On the character's next turn, roll 3d6 and keep the highest two for their first roll.

Health cannot exceed the character's maximum.

Removing a Scar requires magic or about a week of care from a healer. Removing it frees its inventory slot.

Death and dying

The condition that claims your character's final inventory slot determines their fate.

Final condition	Ending
Mutation	The character becomes a Demon. The Aether has changed them beyond themselves.
Scar	The character's body dies. Their spirit passes on, or lingers because of unfinished business.
Fatigue	The character's body gives out from exhaustion.

The character becomes part of the world's lore, and the player makes someone new. A lingering spirit may still matter, but the character's playable life is over.

Character Creation

Make someone who had a life before they became an Arcanist. Four steps are enough to begin. The rest can come out during play.

Step 1: Basic details

Give your character a name and a few details: their age, appearance, voice, and where they are from. A line is plenty.

Then choose a Life Type and record both of its traits. Humans, elves, goblins, cat people, karate turtles, and stranger things all have a place in this world.

Life types

Human

- **Resilient:** Once a day, ignore 1 Fatigue after missing proper sleep.
- **I Know a Guy:** Once per session, declare that your character knows someone useful in the current location. Tell the table how they know each other.

Elf

- **Foresight:** Play one free flashback per session.
- **Old Grudge:** When old knowledge or an old event matters, your character remembers because they were there.

Goblin

- **Overlooked:** Add +1 when your character hides, squeezes, scurries, or goes unnoticed.
- **Goblin Friends:** If a goblin is involved, your character knows them. Tell the table how.

Beastfolk

Choose the animal that shapes your character.

- **Natural Weapons:** Their unarmed attacks deal 2 damage.
- **Keen Senses:** Add +1 when they use one heightened sense appropriate to that animal.

Otherfolk

Otherfolk includes people commonly thought of as monsters, such as crab people, intelligent oozes, lizard folk, vampires, or skeletons.

Choose one body advantage that fits what your character is. Describe what it lets them do.

Examples:

- A shell or thick hide gives 1 Armor.
- A lizard person may use their tail as a weapon.
- A vampire may turn into a bat.
- A skeleton may detach and reattach their limbs.

Step 2: Choose an Archetype

Your character's Archetype represents the life they led before becoming an Arcanist.

Choose one. Take its starting gear, maximum Health, and one Perk. Use its suggested Stats, or arrange **+2, +1, 0, and –1** across the four Stats yourself.

Stat	What it covers
Strength	Muscle, force, fighting hand to hand
Dexterity	Speed, stealth, precision, ranged attacks
Willpower	Endurance and resolve
Charm	Persuasion and presence

Set your character's current Health equal to their maximum Health.

Archetype	Old life	Health
Hunter	Tracked Arcanists for coin, then woke up as one.	7
Thief	Lived by wit, speed, and other people's things.	6
Performer	Lived by fast talk and knowing everyone worth knowing.	6
Monk	Studied the ancient arts and honed their body into a weapon.	7
Fighter	Someone paid them to stand in the way, and they never learned to stop.	8
Witch	Had a place in an order once, then something answered.	5

If none fit, work with the GM to create an old life. Use the same Stat array and choose starting gear, maximum Health, and one Perk based on the existing Archetypes.

Pack the gear

Your character has **12 inventory slots**. Put their Archetype gear into the slots from the top down. Worn Armor does not take a slot.

Small things of the same kind bundle together. Three rations, a handful of arrows, or several iron spikes each take one slot.

Roll **2d6 and multiply the total by 10** for your character's starting coin. Record it in the Coin box on their sheet.

Step 3: Key goals

Write up to four Key Goals your character wants to achieve. They should matter enough to make the character go out into the world and do something about them.

They can be serious or ridiculous:

- Get revenge on the person who killed their mother.
- Burn down the silly hat shop.
- Find out what happened to their sister.
- Buy back the family house.

Choose goals with a clear end. When your character achieves one, cross it off and gain **2 Luck**.
Share the goals with the other players. Their characters might share one, want to help, or have a very good reason to keep that hat shop standing.

Step 4: Starting mutation

Decide whether the Aether has already changed your character.

Start Unchanged

- Begin with no Mutations and no Spell Tags.
- Begin with 0 current Exposure, 0 Luck, no Scars, and no Fatigue.

Start Marked

- Roll on the Mutation table and record the result in inventory slot 12.
- Choose one +1 Spell Tag related to the Mutation or the event that made the character an Arcanist.
- Begin with 0 current Exposure, 0 Luck, no Scars, and no Fatigue.

Starting Marked gives the character more control over magic, but the Aether has already taken one of their twelve slots.

Archetypes

Hunter

Your character hunted Arcanists for coin, following rumors, studying habits, and learning what frightened people would pay to have someone taken away. Then the Aether changed them too. They still know the trade, and the people who practice it.

Strength	Dexterity	Willpower	Charm
+1	+1	+1	–1

Starting Health 7

Starting Gear

Short sword, 2 damage

Crossbow, 2 damage

Manacles

Iron spikes

Big hammer, 1 damage

Rations x3

Chainmail, Armor 1

d6	Perk
1	Roll with advantage when following tracks.
2	Add Dexterity to damage with a bow or crossbow.
3	Roll with advantage when telling if someone is lying.
4	Pinning Shot: When you roll double 4s on a ranged attack, your character may pin the target's clothing or body to a nearby surface. The target must spend an action pulling free. Resolve damage and complications normally.
5	Your character is an expert at barbecuing and slow cooking meat.
6	Living Rough: Your character knows what is safe to eat and where to find shelter. Once a day, they can gather enough food in the wild to replace one ration for each member of the party.

Thief

Your character has a talent for getting into places and leaving with things. Locked doors are an invitation, rats are useful company, and a small explosion can cover a surprising number of mistakes.

Strength	Dexterity	Willpower	Charm
–1	+2	+1	0

Starting Health 6

Starting Gear

Double daggers, 2 damage

Leather Armor, Armor 1

Lockpick kit

Grappling hook

60 feet of rope

Smoke pellets that hide the character from sight

Rations x3

d6	Perk
1	Super Taster: Your character can identify a substance by tasting even the smallest trace. Poison, strange ink, expensive perfume, someone's lunch. They can even tell what kind of creature left a smear of dried blood. Knowing what it is does not make it safe to taste.
2	A Knack for Explosions: Your character can build small explosives from common items and always has something on hand to start a fire.
3	Sleight of Hand: Roll with advantage when pickpocketing or lock-picking.
4	Vital Strike: When you roll double 4s while stabbing a creature unaware of your character's presence, the blade finds a vital spot. The creature dies before the blade is pulled free. Mythic creatures still require their Weakness to be exploited.
5	Call in a Favor: Once a session, you can declare that a thief, smuggler, or other shady person nearby owes your character a small favor. Neither is willing to explain why.
6	Rat Whisperer: Your character can talk with rats and bargain with them to run errands, spy, collect information, or do other favors. Rats want food or favors in return, and their requests are not always reasonable.

Performer

Your character learned to turn heads before they learned to earn an honest living. A street-corner singer, a dazzling circus dancer, or a hungry kid tumbling for coins. They know how to work a crowd, make an entrance, and turn a little trouble into a show.

Strength	Dexterity	Willpower	Charm
–1	+1	0	+2

Starting Health **6**

Starting Gear

Short sword, 2 damage

Disguise kit

A ring of stolen keys

Padded coat, Armor 1

Torch

Rations x3

d6	Perk
1	Once a session, name someone who owes your character a favor. They do.
2	Musical Number: Once a day, your character can entice a roomful of ordinary people into an elaborate song and choreographed dance. Bakers, pickpockets, and visiting aunts know every word and step, and gleefully join in to perform the number.
3	Perfect Pitch: Your character can reproduce any voice, melody, or sound they have heard. A birdcall, a squeaky hinge, or the captain ordering the guards to stand down.
4	Kindred Spirits: When you roll double 4s on a Charm roll, your character and the target form a sudden, deep, and lasting bond. Neither can explain it, but both feel it. Resolve the roll normally.
5	Throw Your Voice: Your character can make their voice sound as though it comes from anywhere nearby. A locked cupboard, someone else's mouth, or just behind the guard.
6	Master of Disguise: Your character is an expert with makeup, costumes, and accents, with an uncanny ability to convincingly pass as all sorts of people.

Monk

Your character practices ancient martial arts, leaping between rooftops, balancing on swaying branches, and meeting drawn steel with empty hands. Their body is a weapon, their mind just as sharp. They might catch a bullet with their teeth or meditate in the heart of a storm.

Strength	Dexterity	Willpower	Charm
+1	+2	0	–1

Starting Health 7

Starting Gear

Walking staff, 2 damage

Bandages and salves, 3 uses, restore 1d6 Health

60 feet of knotted rope

Throwing stars x4

Torch

Rations x3

d6	Perk
1	Add Strength to damage with unarmed strikes.
2	Meeting Steel: Spend 1 Luck when a melee attack would hit your character. They turn the blow aside, taking no damage, or redirect it into another target within the attack's reach.
3	Light as a Leaf: Your character can leap 20 feet and balance on branches, blades, or slender objects that should never support their weight. A foothold no wider than a toe is enough. They can fight while perched there.
4	Sweeping Strike: When you roll double 4s on any melee attack, your character can knock the target off their feet.
5	A Most Humble Demonstration: Your character can split a brick, catch a fly with chopsticks, or balance a full teapot on one finger. Ordinary displays of precision and discipline need no roll. Doing them while someone tries to kill them is another matter.
6	Commune with Spirits: Once a session, play a free flashback to a time your character meditated and spoke with a spirit. Describe the guidance or favor they sought and how it helps in the present. Resolve the scene using the normal flashback rules.

Fighter

Your character has made a living with a weapon and their grit. Guarding caravans, fought someone else's war, or stood outside a door without asking what happened behind it. They know how to hold their ground, look after their equipment, and keep going when a sensible person would stop.

Strength	Dexterity	Willpower	Charm
+2	+1	0	–1

Starting Health 8

Starting Gear

Longsword, 3 damage

Chainmail, Armor 1

Shield, Armor 1

Torch x2

Rations x3

d6	Perk
1	Add Strength to damage in hand-to-hand combat.
2	Spend a luck to take a hit meant for someone at Close range.
3	Dual Wielder: When your character fights with a melee weapon in each hand, add +1 damage to the attack before doubling or tripling. Roll once and use the higher weapon damage. They cannot use a shield while fighting this way.
4	Disarm: When you roll double 4s on a melee attack, your character may knock a weapon from the target's hand. Resolve damage and complications normally.
5	Your character can mend a battlefield wound and restore 1 Health as an action.
6	An Old Comrade: Once a session, declare that someone present served alongside your character. Describe what happened the last time they saw each other. They will hear your character out, though they may still hold a grudge.

Witch

Your character belonged to a coven, learning the guarded secrets of a dark and ancient order. They studied forbidden rites, bargained with strange powers, and learned which names must never be spoken aloud. They have since left the coven, though its teachings are harder to leave behind.

Strength	Dexterity	Willpower	Charm
–1	0	+2	+1

Starting Health **5**

Starting Gear

A staff from the character's old order, holding 9 Exposure and an effect they did not create

Sleep powder

A bone-handled knife, 2 damage

Torch

Rations x3

d6	Perk
1	Striking beauty: Once a long rest, you can charm people simply by getting them to look at you for one round.
2	1. Spell Tag: Gain or improve a Spell Tag when the kept casting dice are double 4s.
3	Explosive knowledge: You know how make bombs out of common plants and chemicals
4	Cat Friends: Your character can befriend as many ordinary cats as they wish. Roll to see if they follow your character's orders.
5	Talented caster: Roll with advantage when casting with a Spell Tag.
6	Crow Friends: Your character has a murder of crows that obeys your commands.

Game Master Guide

Monsters

Four numbers and two questions.

Threat, Damage, Health, Armor, then what undoes it and what it wants. That fits on an index card.

Tiers

d6	Tier	Stats and example
1	**Pest**	**Threat:** –1; **Damage:** 1; **Health:** 3; **Armor:** 0; Goblin.
2	**Minion**	**Threat:** 0; **Damage:** 2; **Health:** 5; **Armor:** 1; Bandit or bear.
3	**Glass Cannon**	**Threat:** +1; **Damage:** 3; **Health:** 10; **Armor:** 0; Mummy.
4	**Horror**	**Threat:** +2; **Damage:** 3; **Health:** 15; **Armor:** 2; Ooze.
5	**Boss**	**Threat:** +2; **Damage:** 4; **Health:** 20; **Armor:** 3; Demon.
6	**Mythic**	**Threat:** +3; **Damage:** 5; **Health:** 30; **Armor:** 5; Dragon.

Choose the tier level that fits, or roll 1d6 and let the dice decide. Rolling works well when you are improvising or want the danger to surprise you too.

Running one

- Roll 2d6 plus Threat when a monster attacks. See Core Mechanics.
- Damage applies to all its attacks. A bear might bite or swipe, but both deal 2 damage.
- Weakness is what gives the characters an edge. Plant a way to discover it: a corpse, a book, a survivor, or someone who faced the creature before.
- Desire is what the monster wants besides killing the characters. Anything with a Desire can potentially be bargained with.
- For a monster caster, roll twice on Spell Tag Sparks and combine the results into a casting theme.
- A group of monsters attacking one character at the same time rolls once, using its highest Threat and best single Damage. Its numbers can still surround characters, block exits, or create other complications.
- A monster with Threat +2 or higher can attack twice on its turn. An individual monster may break this rule when it fits.

Worked monsters are in the Bestiary.

Morale

When a monster falls to half Health or less, roll 2d6 plus Threat.

Total	Result
6 or less	It flees, surrenders, or bargains.
7 to 9	It changes tactics or pursues its Desire.
10 or greater	It holds.

The GM may call for another morale roll after the monster takes more damage. Mindless, driven, or bound creatures do not roll Morale.

Mythic monsters

Health alone never kills a Mythic. Its Weakness is the only thing that can end it.

When a Mythic reaches zero Health without its Weakness being exploited, it withdraws or changes. If it changes, restore its Health and make it worse.

Telegraph this from the beginning. Wounds close. Severed limbs reform. The blade comes away clean. Killing the figure beneath the robe only kills the robe.

Bestiary

Goblin

Tier 1
Pest

Threat	Damage	Health	Armor
–1	1	3	0

Attacks: Rusty knife, rocks, biting.
Weakness: Bright light drives them back.
Desire: Something shiny, and to see tomorrow.

Bear

Tier 2
Minion

Threat	Damage	Health	Armor
0	2	5	1

Attacks: Bite, swipe, bull rush.
Weakness: Fire, which no animal will face.
Desire: To be left alone.

Mummy

Tier 3
Glass Cannon

Threat	Damage	Health	Armor
+1	3	10	0

Attacks: Grasping hands, choking wrappings.
Weakness: Fire.
Desire: To punish whoever opened the door.

Ooze

Tier 4
Horror

Threat	Damage	Health	Armor
+2	3	15	2

Attacks: Engulf, acid touch, drops from above.
Weakness: Salt, or high ground.
Desire: To dissolve and absorb metals.

The Frayed Man

Tier 5
Boss

Too many joints, a second mouth, something moving under the coat.

Threat	Damage	Health	Armor
+2	4	20	3

Attacks: Grasping limbs, a crushing grip.
Casts: Up to 8 Exposure. Bind, Drain, Mutate.
Weakness: Hot gossip. He just cannot get enough.
Desire: To kill Steve.

The Last Dragon

Tier 6
Mythic

Ancient, scarred, too large for the ruins it calls home, and remembers every wound.

Threat	Damage	Health	Armor
+3	5	30	5

Attacks: Crushing jaws, sweeping tail, furnace breath.
Weakness: It must be killed with something that has never been used as a weapon.
Desire: To destroy every surviving account of dragons so no one remembers how to kill one.

Reference Tables

Mutation Table

d66	Mutation
11	Eyes: Roll 1d6: (1) glow, (2) reflective black, (3) faded gray, (4) blood red, (5) wood, (6) purple
12	Sharp teeth
13	Long pointed elf ears
14	One body part doubles in size. Roll 1d6: (1) fingers, (2) forearms, (3) neck, (4) calves, (5) hands, (6) hips
15	Claws
16	Forked tongue
21	Your limbs become removable and reattachable.
22	Covered in: Roll 1d6: (1) fur, (2) feathers, (3) warts, (4) tiny blinking eyes, (5) moving symbols, (6) grass
23	A large shell grows on your back
24	Skin changes: Roll 1d6: (1) bark, (2) metal, (3) scales, (4) rock, (5) barnacles, (6) see-through skin
25	Grow a large tail
26	Turn into a talking version of your childhood pet
31	1d6 more eyes
32	Covered in moss, and vining plants
33	Antlers
34	Grow long, pointed horns from your head
35	Your skull becomes soft and your brain doubles in size, pulsing with light. You can read people's emotions.
36	Grow wings
41	Your flesh becomes soft wax that can be reshaped.
42	Hear and smell 10x better. Loud sounds or strong smells bother you.
43	Become a talking house cat
44	Burning touch
45	Grow 1d6 long tentacles from your back
46	Bird legs
51	A second mouth
52	A second face, on the back of your head
53	Reptilian, cold and slit-eyed
54	Limbs become moving roots
55	Your size changes. Roll 1d6: (1) mouse, (2) cat, (3) young child, (4) horse, (5) one-story house, (6) four-story building
56	A single red eye grows from your forehead while your other eyes shrink to nothing
61	Float 4 feet above the ground
62	Become a moving piece of ice and freeze everything you touch
63	Become faceless
64	Your form changes. Roll 1d6: (1) gas, (2) ooze, (3) water, (4) rock, (5) fire, (6) energy
65	Your hands become giant crab claws
66	Come apart into a swarm of bugs with a hive mind.

Wild Magic

d66	Wild Magic
11	Wild lights fill the sky.
12	Every is covered in sticky green slime.
13	Total darkness covered the play area for 1d6 days.
14	Inanimate objects come to life. Roll d6: 1. They are all singing a childish song, 2. Screaming because nothing makes sense, 3. Thinks the first largish creature they see is their mommy, 4. All singing different songs... badly, 5. Scary laughing, 6. Projectile committing... everywhere
15	Everyone is teleported to a small bathroom of, Roll d6: 1. a castle during a wedding, 2. a clown performance at a low rent circus, 3. a den of crime during a raid, 4. a kids birthday party where no one showed up, 5. a keep on a mountain peak deep in the north, 6. a closed art museum
16	Tiny flying fairies emerge and shoot stinging blasts of energy at everyone.
21	The whole region is cast into a permanent Snowy winter.
22	Flash flood rolls through the area. Wiping out buildings and changing the landscape.
23	Gravity loses its grip, it's like walking on the moon.
24	The wondering magical merchant appears with strange things to sell. Will take your soul as payment. Harming him is a bad idea.
25	Everyone you can see grows a tail
26	Everyone you can see forgets who they are and why they are there.
31	The air becomes so think you can swim through it for 1d6 days.
32	For 1 hour gravity shifts to the walls or the ceiling.
33	The caster is infused with intense electricity. They can shoot lightning from their hands for 1d6 days.
34	Everyone nearby shrinks to mouse size for 1d6 hours.
35	A dense forest and mature forest instantly grow around you in every direction for miles.
36	For 1d6 days every door within a mile of you opens to the spirit realm.
41	Fog so dense you can't see your hand in front of your face. Lasts 1d6 hours.
42	Everyone nearby becomes transparent except for their bones for the 1d6 days.
43	Nearby metal softens like clay for 1d6 hours.
44	1d6 individual in the room are turned into vampires.
45	Dead creature claw their way through the floor. 1d6 of them every hour for 1d6 months.
46	A huge creature falls from the sky: Roll 1d6, 1. A whale, 2. A dragon, 3. Gelatinous cube, 4. Spooky ghost, 5. Huge red dog, 6. A giant looking for his goose that lays golden eggs.
51	Every nonliving thing nearby turns to sand.
52	You switch bodies with the person or creature you are looking at.
53	Everyone you can see is turned into: 1. Children, 2. Very old women, 3. Talking dogs, 4. Talking cats, 5. Talking raccoons, 6. Cookie people
54	A giant pyramid emerges from the ground under you. Its contents likely treasures of a demon who was trying to hide from prying eyes.
55	Plants erupt from every crack, splitting roads, walls, and foundations as they consume the area.
56	A pillar of glowing energy erupts from the ground 20 feet tall, 3 feet wide. It emits a lot of heat.
61	The surrounding area becomes dead land. Plants die, water spoils, and nothing grows here anymore.
62	A portal to a void dimension tears open and stays open, pulling things into it like a vacuum.
63	Gravity reverses across the area permanently. Anything unanchored falls into the sky.
64	Every one near by rolls on the mutation table.
65	You become invisible for 1d6 days.
66	The area around you is torn from its spot and floats into the clouds. Where it is now stuck. Slowly drifting through the sky.

Spell Tag Sparks

When a player needs a Spell Tag idea, roll once or choose one. To create a monster caster, roll twice and combine the results into a casting theme. **Fire + Memory** might burn away memories. **Bone + Space** might call distant skeletons.

d66	Spark
11	Fire
12	Ice
13	Lightning
14	Wind
15	Water
16	Stone
21	Light
22	Darkness
23	Sound
24	Gravity
25	Time
26	Magnetism
31	Speed
32	Slime
33	Scale
34	Plants
35	Animals
36	Swarms
41	Explosion
42	locating
43	Undead
44	Illusion
45	Acid
46	Speed
51	Flying
52	Binding
53	Transformation
54	Invisibility
55	Sleep
56	Healing
61	Portal
62	Mind reading
63	Duplication
64	Disease
65	Decay
66	Weather

Key Ideas

Making money

Arcanists can make and sell relics. For some, it is a living. Wizarding schools may keep their Arcanist suppliers on the down-low. Common folk do not need to know that their magic items come from people slowly turning into monsters.

Magic is a team sport

Magic can be a team effort. Separate casts can build on each other.

One character creates fire, another opens a portal, and a third blows the fire through it. Price and roll each cast separately. Each character gains Exposure for their own cast.

Arcanists might be scary

Anyone who can rewrite reality is dangerous. Common folk may fear Arcanists. Powerful people may hunt, recruit, hide, or control them before they grow into demigods.

Key Terms

- **Aether:** The particles and patterns that make up reality.
- **Arcanist:** A person who can perceive and command those patterns.
- **Exposure:** Raw Aether accumulated through casting.
- **Magic Magnitude:** The overall scale of a spell, setting its Exposure cost. See Casting Magic.
- **Mutation:** A permanent change caused by Exposure.
- **Fatigue:** Exhaustion caused by going without proper rest or food, or consuming poison. Each Fatigue occupies one inventory slot.
- **Spell Tag:** Something the character's magic has learned to do reliably.
- **Health:** How much damage a character or monster can take before suffering worse consequences.
- **Relic:** An object that stores Exposure and performs one kind of magic.
- **Frayed:** A common term for an Arcanist visibly changed by Exposure.
- **Demon:** An Arcanist whose final inventory slot was claimed by a Mutation.

The Arcane Aether

Armor

Broken

Health

Max | Current

STR | **DEX** | **WILL** | **CHARM** | **COIN**

Luck

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

Inventory

1		
2		
3		
4		
5		
6		
7		
8		
9		
10		
11		
12		

Mutations, Scars, and Fatigue

Spell Tags

Aether Exposure

1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

Character Details

Name **Age**

Life Type **Archetype**

Description

Other Details / Notes

Key Goals

Traits & Perks